Men & Machines

The sun's final rays peek over the horizon for the day. An etude of orange and pink suspends itself against the firmament, waiting for space and its stars to take watch. It follows the lone sentinel, Veryn.

He exits Central Park and saunters down Fifth Avenue, his loafers scraping across the littered concrete. A few minutes of walking leads him to a building taller than his neck can tolerate. "Hylic Partners," the channel letters indicate, glowing yellow on the overhead cabinet sign. His choice of a navy-blue suit, navy-blue pants, and red tie fits with that of the ashen employees inside and outside, who only pay him a passing glance as he waits in line to scan his ID.

Two concierges at the front desk buzz through the lobby's chatter. One fashions a pair of smartglasses, while the other is blindfolded.

"So, how'd dinner with Daniel go?" the blindfolded miss queries. Her nametag reads as "Rae."

The bespectacled lass, Les, pouts, "Remember when you went out with that one guy a few months ago? You two were watching the race, and then, like, that accident happened, right?"

“Yeah?”

“Right, it was like that, but it was one of the new trains flying at us instead. Went straight through the big window at the front.”

“Why can’t they just install the new forcefields there already? The engineers are so lazy!”

“I know, right? It was super annoying, but whatever. Danny asked to go home after that, and I was super bored for the rest of the day.”

“Guys are so sensitive these days! Ugh, they should get their genes reprogrammed or something.”

“I know, right?”

The sound of footsteps draws their attention from each other. The source grows closer without adopting a rhythm, deaf to the drumbeat that the workers are playing.

Les pokes her head out from behind her computer. “Rae, it’s that guy again,” she whispers.

Rae rests her head on Les's, snickering. "What do you think he's here for today, Les?"

"Definitely not shadowing another meeting. His clothes are wrinklier than your bedsheets."

Les adjusts her glasses and leans a bit forward, her chest typing nonsense with the keyboard in front of her. She points her head to the entrance, though her pupils follow the navy-blue man in her periphery.

"His buttons are a whole other fiasco," Les comments, shaking her head.

Rae giggles, "Eight bucks says he jumps off the roof."

Les scoffs, "Deal!"

Veryn wades through the sea of workers, stopping at the elevator. Everyone surrounding him carries the same suitcase and tie about them. The person at his port guffaws at a colleague's shanty. The person at his starboard gapes at the LED lighting, arms crossed. Each expression shifts in their own directions, though they all end up in a frown.

When the elevator bell dings and doors slide open, hundreds of suited men and women spill out into the lobby. Veryn slips in and presses a button labeled "103." Within a

minute, the doors slide shut and the cab shoots upward to the man's destination. Amidst the minute, he anchors himself against the railing, staring at the sunset as it stares at him.

He shifts his weight towards the window, plopping his forehead on the glass. *Is my vision getting worse, or are the stars playing hide and seek with the pollution*?

The ding of the bell cuts the man's internal dialogue short. He surges ahead, sailing up the flights of stairs adjacent to the elevator. On the way up, he encounters three pairs of titanium doors. Each blocks a new floor; however, his ID escorts him past them.

Behind the last set of doors is the roof, which greets Veryn with a sudden, -2.4°F gust of wind. His body broaches to the wind by an inch, then rights itself. A shaky exhalation escapes him.

He steps off the circular platform and drifts to the metallic railing at the edge. Before he can take a seat, however, the belated new-year lighting consumes his gaze from hundreds of feet below. His jaw goes slack, his shoulders drop, and his pupils begin to drift outwards. Almost ten minutes pass before he shakes himself awake. *Not now*.

He hops to seat himself atop the railing, perching on the skyscraper like an eagle. His outerwear whips in the wind like wings, though it continues to conform to his body. He

squints at the sky with a frown-smile, whilst only black reflects in his eyes. Apricity embraces his form, though he speaks to it before reciprocating.

“How did they mess up the one view that was entirely meant for them?” he whispers to the Apricity.

He listens for a response, hands pocketed. Its zephyrs whistle back. His smile loses its teeth.

“But why lose what you gave them, in exchange for artificial warmth?”

The Apricity’s hands ruffle his hair, laughing with power that Veryn regards with a sneer. “The northerly winds aren’t toys,” he scolds. “And speak aloud, we’re alone up here.”

Its voice cries out in the wilderness, “Don’t be so quick to mistake my humor for hubris, old friend.”

“Your jokes haven’t gotten any better since you executed the protocols,” the listener comments, shaking his head.

“I’ll get a hearty giggle out of you by the invention of the Dyson sphere,” the presence claims.

“You made that same claim during the Crusades.”

“Regarding what?”

“The Manhattan Project’s output!”

“Right, I did say that, didn’t I? The spacetime continuum is quite the athlete.”

Veryn chuckles, “And we bet on *them* winning the race.”

“By *them*, you mean humanity?”

“Of course.”

Veryn’s chest balloons with breath as a smirk finds his face. “You know, they’ve recently been pushing forward a newer title: amelioration,” he divulges.

The voice remains silent, and the gales slow to a breeze, as if to stop before crossing the street. From below, automobiles honk and the crowd mills about. Veryn nods and quiets himself as well, though he jumps at each crest in the acoustics.

“I’m afraid that moniker eludes their current capabilities,” the presence resumes.

“Agreed.”

“But, it’s not a bad thing. It shows they’re still learning more about themselves, room to improve and all.”

“Did you expect them to plateau?”

“There was, is, and always will be that kind of possibility.”

“You were, are, and always will be worrying in that omnipresent tense and sense, Pol—”

“Ah-ah, my name is forbidden now, remember?”

“By the Sovereigns, do you think *anyone* conveying your name correctly will cause such problems?”

“You remember the First Calamity, don’t you?”

Veryn raises an eyebrow. “And something of the sort will happen again?”

“Are you curious enough to find out?”

Veryn rolls his eyes, crossing his arms. “Be straight with me. What are all of these ridiculous battles you’re fighting even for?”

The man flicks his wrist at the city below them. The Apricity whistles, “Are we not soldiers of our own cause?”

He snarls at the denizens of Manhattan. “Are we? *WE* are letting humanity tread this fatal trend, with impossible challenges dictating their lives rather than clear kindness. Truth be told, we—no, *you* have effaced yourself from the grand tapestry! What from time immemorial made you so difficult?”

“It’s a ruinous saga of gods and monsters not worth explaining.”

The civil twilight dances in Veryn′s eyes. Curtains close, and another act begins. A shift in the wind starts. This time, the sky watches the two directors. The first evening star—a star that isn’t a star—twinkles in the night sky.

“...Do you see that ‘star’ in the sky? How it sits on stage by its lonesome?” the voice indicates.

Veryn tilts his gaze skyward. “Yeah.”

“That celestial candle is lit for the first Sovereign of the second generation, Nora Zorana. Her origin is that of your post—the pale blue dot—and I’m too sure of her ascension to heights far higher than this plane of existence permits.”

“Your point being?”

“Nora’s existence is—or more precisely will be—one of infinitely many stories writing itself, regardless of perfection or the lack thereof. I suggest you keep a close eye on her.”

“Ah, but what’s so special about a mortal like her, let alone a human? Her species only constitutes loud, proud creatures.”

“Clandestine ones that know how to cover their eyes. I assume you’ve never gotten close to one.”

“Not necessarily.”

“Then perhaps she will light the way into your heart, or at least shed some on the… *centerpiece* I’m hoping to draw.”

“Gatekeeping your plans as always!” the ancient aide mocks. “But I’ll keep to your ‘wisdom.’”

Before Veryn can dismount the railing, a mushroom cloud grows in the distance, painting the night with ghastly light. He extends his left hand towards the destruction and closes his fist at it, forming an invisible bubble around the explosion site.

“Mitigating the damage?”

“More like saving the ecosystem. Those kids are too powerful to be playing here,” Veryn remarks, placing his hand back on the railing.

“The Calamity Colors, I presume?”

“Of course, as it’s another time for them to coruscate, the internet and all.”

“Right, we knew digital technology would be a calamity demanding their presence. As were all the other calamities.”

Hearing those words, his breathing becomes shallower. His blinking slows, and the muscles around Veryn’s eyes relax as the pupils wander. Time itself turns back to see the notches on the wall.

“Like that war betwixt the rivers,” he gesticulates, drawing an outline of Sumer in the air.

The trees below leap from the sway of a waltz to a jive. The metal Veryn sits atop creaks in tandem.

“Like that war with the wooden horse.”

Gusts of wind slam into Veryn, though he remains seated for their dialogue. Goosebumps form on his skin and his teeth chatter, though his words resonate with the same pitch and volume.

“Like the Crusades.”

Phantom sensations knock upon the door of Veryn’s Headspace. He invites them in like a fool would for vampires.

“Like those wars around the planet.”

The chambers of his heart reverberate with the roaring of men and machines. Ashes linger in the air. Copper stains his tongue. Armored men and hot steel flash across his vision. His arm reaches up once more to hold a gloved hand, and his eyes moisten the moment their fingertips meet. He leans forward, his hand almost wrapping around the other; yet, it pulls away and returns to the Ashes.

“Seems you’ve lost your pieces too,” the wind whispers.

Veryn's body wobbles headlong. "You won't catch me, will you?"

Gravel gathers in the voice, scratching like chalk against a board for each phrase it conveys.

"One must fall to fly, Veryn. Heaven and Earth are a 'package deal' as a salesman might suggest."

The man's chest caves and shivers as he oscillates between ground and sky. A ringing sensation gores his ears with a pike. His hands flail and thrash about, as if he's conducting an insubordinate orchestra. From his viewpoint, car lights, streetlights, and traffic lights melt into one amalgamation.

"And if I don't want to fly?"

A singular gust of wind strikes Veryn's stern. He staggers forward, diving into the cityscape.

"Then you will spend every eternity pursuing a compromise that doesn't exist."